



Hey, Researcher!

Here Are Some Open Source Tools For You!

In this article, I will take a look at getting going with LaTeX, Gnuplot, GNU Octave, Python scientific libraries, Beamer, and some other tools and libraries. On Linux, you can focus on the real job instead of bothering about setting up your tools. This article is therefore an unabashed claim about how cool it is to work with these tools while you focus on your research.

*M*y encounter with Linux happened accidentally 10 years ago, accompanied by the fun of wiping out and putting in a Linux distribution numerous times on my first computer—without having a clue about how to work on it! After a lot of such iterations, I finally settled in, and have been working on it full time for the last five years.

That ‘accident’ 10 years ago stood me in good stead, both when I was working at a software company, and now, as I work in a research lab, where we need to plot figures, run batch jobs remotely, perform scientific and numerical computing, and (last, but not least) publish results by writing papers. Just a few

days before I wrote to *LFY*’s editor about this article, I helped a friend (a Windows-user) draw some plots for her paper (fixing them for publication), all the time wondering, “Gee, how do Windows users do it?” Most tools that I used were primarily for Linux. On Linux, things are so much easier. You can focus on the real job, instead of bothering about setting up your tools.

Some of these tools can be set up on a non-Linux system too; it would, in fact, be a good exercise to get all the tools that I talk about here, working on Windows! Note that while the primary focus here is to introduce my readers to these tools, and not to force them to convert to Linux, I will address usage on a Linux system only, and won’t cover any non-Linux issues.